

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For managers, cross-border teams, HR partners, and meeting facilitators.

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accountability

Responsibility for explaining decisions and following through on agreed work.

acknowledgment

Recognition of another person's contribution or confirmation that a message was received.

action item

A specific task agreed during a discussion, usually assigned to a person.

assumption

Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

behavioral example

A specific description of what a person did or said.

boundary

A limit on acceptable conduct, responsibility, access, or scope.

clarification

A question or explanation that makes meaning more precise.

commitment

An explicit promise or accepted responsibility to do something.

deadline

The latest agreed or required time for completing an action.

decision rights

The allocation of authority to recommend, approve, or make particular decisions.

expectation

A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

facilitation

Guiding a discussion so people can contribute, understand differences, and reach useful next steps.

feedback

Information about performance intended to support understanding and improvement.

meeting minutes

A written record of key discussion points, decisions, and agreed actions.

objection

A stated concern or reason for not accepting a proposal.

operating agreement

An agreed description of how people will coordinate work and responsibilities.

role clarity

A shared understanding of a person's responsibilities and authority.

stakeholder engagement

The involvement and interaction of people affected by an activity or decision.

support plan

Agreed actions and resources intended to help a person or team meet an identified need.

tradeoff

A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

trust

Confidence that someone will act reliably and respectfully.

workload

The amount and type of work assigned or required over a period.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Disagree with a useful reason

I understand the goal. My concern is

That statement goes beyond

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Check meaning before assuming agreement

In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Challenge ideas respectfully

A colleague says, "This proposal makes no sense." The group goes quiet. You want to hear the concern without accepting personal attacks.

I'd like to understand the objection. Which assumption do you disagree with? Please focus on the proposal so we can examine it together.

Try it again: The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

03 | Make authority and participation clear

Your team wants more direction, but the manager has been answering every question. A new hire has stopped offering ideas.

I'll make the final decision on staffing. Before that, I want each of you to suggest one option. You can speak now or send a note after the meeting.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

04 | Negotiate realistic commitments

Headquarters asks for a report on Friday. The local team can produce verified figures on Monday or a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

We can send an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday. Which would meet your need? If we send the estimate, I'll label the figures as provisional.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

05 | Include every voice in a meeting

Three people speak at once during a hybrid meeting. A remote colleague's question is missed, and nobody knows who can approve the plan.

Let's hear Morgan's question first. Then we'll take one comment at a time. Before we finish, can we confirm who approves the plan and when?

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

06 | Give specific, useful feedback

Two weekly reports arrived a day after the agreed deadline. The manager does not know the reason. Other teams depend on the figures.

The last two reports arrived on Tuesday instead of Monday. That delayed our review. What is getting in the way, and what support would help you meet Monday's deadline?

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

07 | Coordinate across offices

Headquarters requests daily detail. The branch says the reporting takes an hour each day. Neither side has explained what information it actually needs.

Headquarters needs early notice of delays; the branch needs time to deliver the work. Could we try a short daily exception report and review the arrangement in two weeks?

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

08 | Repair misunderstandings and build trust

You interrupted a colleague twice while they explained a concern. They later say they felt dismissed. The concern is still unresolved.

I interrupted you and missed part of your concern. I'm sorry. Could we return to it now? At our next meeting, I'll let you finish before I respond.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Use the language responsibly

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.